

GA-OP-04

Staff Gap Coverage & Temporary Reassignment

How HODs arrange safe, practical coverage when an absence or staffing gap affects the school day.

APPLIES TO

Gardner Academy employees and relevant staff

AUTHORITY

Gardner Academy operational, staffing, and supervision standard

01 Purpose

Staff absences and unexpected gaps must be handled in a way that protects supervision, learning continuity, safety, and the orderly operation of the school day. This policy explains who makes the coverage decision and what employees are expected to do.

02 HOD coverage decision

The responsible Head of Department determines how a staff gap will be covered. Employees must not independently split a class, move students, reassign a colleague, close an activity, or change a duty rotation unless authorised to do so.

03 Coverage options

Depending on the needs of the day, the Head of Department may:

- Temporarily move an employee from one department, class, programme, or duty area to another.
- Split a classroom group and place students with other suitable groups or classes.
- Combine or adjust activities, supervision areas, duties, or schedules.
- Assign available support staff to assist with supervision, preparation, or instruction suited to their training and background.
- Personally step into the classroom, supervision area, programme, or operational duty.
- Use another reasonable and lawful arrangement that maintains safety and causes the least disruption.

04 How the decision is made

Coverage is determined according to the circumstances of that day. Relevant factors include group sizes, student needs, supervision requirements, employee workloads, staff training and background, timetable commitments, available spaces and resources, and which arrangement will cause the least disruption to learning and school operations.

05 Employee responsibilities

Employees must:

- Report an absence, delay, or inability to perform an assigned duty as early as possible through the approved process.
- Follow a reasonable and lawful temporary reassignment made by the responsible Head of Department.
- Provide or receive a clear handover of students, duties, plans, materials, medication, safety information, and urgent work.
- Support colleagues and students calmly without presenting the temporary arrangement as a conflict or inconvenience.
- Continue following safeguarding, active-supervision, confidentiality, and authorised-collector requirements in the temporary placement.
- Promptly explain any support, training, authorisation, physical-capacity, or safety concern so that appropriate guidance can be given. A concern must not be used to abandon the assignment or leave students without coverage.

06 Training, support, and expected effort

Lack of previous training or experience is not, by itself, grounds for refusing a reasonable and lawful temporary assignment. An employee who needs help must request training, guidance, materials, modelling, planning support, or clarification and must participate in the support provided.

For example, a teacher temporarily assigned to teach English may not refuse solely because they have not previously been trained specifically in English instruction. Training and support will be provided as needed, and the teacher is expected to make a genuine effort to learn, prepare, apply feedback, and improve until they can fulfil the assigned expectation.

An employee must immediately raise a concern where a task would be unlawful, requires a licence or authorisation the employee does not hold, creates an immediate safety risk, or cannot be performed because of a genuine physical or medical limitation.

Temporary nature and communication

A same-day coverage decision is temporary unless the employee receives a different written instruction. Employees must check where they are assigned, which group or duties they are responsible for, how long the arrangement applies, and who receives the final handover. Questions or concerns must be raised privately with the Head of Department and must not be discussed negatively in front of students or families.